

TX.4 Where to File Directory

How to pin down which track your lot is on, the state agencies and big-jurisdiction offices a Texas owner-builder deals with, and a page to write down what you confirmed.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Texas has no single permit counter: each city administers its own permits and code editions, county programs vary, and several state agencies each own one piece of the picture. Confirm every item with the office that will actually issue it before you rely on it.

SETTLE YOUR TRACK FIRST — CITY LIMITS, ETJ, OR UNINCORPORATED

Every requirement in this kit branches on where the lot sits, and there are three positions, not two. **Inside city limits:** the city permits and inspects — Track A. **Unincorporated county:** no building permit, five separate approvals — Track B. **The extraterritorial jurisdiction (ETJ)** is the ring outside the limits where the city is not your permit office but can still reach you — most commonly through platting. If you are in an ETJ, work Track B and ask the city in writing which of its regulations it applies there.

Get it in writing, from both sides

Ask the city's planning/permitting department AND the county: "Is this parcel inside the city limits, inside the ETJ, or unincorporated — and who issues residential permits for it?" Cities annex, ETJs move, and online maps lag. A written answer with a date is the first page of your project file. Filing with the wrong office — or assuming no office exists — costs weeks either way.

ETJ release: since SB 2038 (2023), landowners in most ETJ areas may petition for release from the city's ETJ (Local Gov't Code § 42.102) — and if the city sits on a valid petition, "*the area is released by operation of law*" (§ 42.105(d)). 2025's HB 2512 narrowed which areas qualify (§ 42.101), so check the exclusions before you plan around a release.

Loc. Gov't Code §§ 42.101, 42.102, 42.105(d), read August 2026.

STATE AGENCIES — WHO OWNS WHICH PIECE

State agencies and what each is actually for

Agency	Why you would contact them	Website
TDLR Licensing & Regulation	Electricians (licensing and the homeowner-exemption page), HVAC contractors, water well drillers and pump installers. Also the agency whose program list proves no GC license exists.	tdlr.texas.gov
TSBPE Plumbing Examiners	Plumbing licensing statewide — still a standalone board through at least September 1, 2033 (Occ. Code § 1301.003). The place to confirm the homestead exemption for your situation, and the current plumbing-code edition.	tsbpe.texas.gov
TCEQ Environmental Quality	The OSSF (septic) program: rules, the authorized-agent county lookup map, Form 0235 where TCEQ itself permits, and licensing of installers and site evaluators. Also a route to groundwater-district maps (with the Texas Water Development Board's viewers).	tceq.texas.gov
TDI — Windstorm Dept. of Insurance	Coastal catastrophe-area list, the WPI-1 filing, inspections, and the WPI-8 certificate search.	tdi.texas.gov/wind
SECO State Energy Conservation Office	The statewide energy-code status page (single-family) and the adoption process — check it before you rely on the 2015 edition staying current.	comptroller.texas.gov/ programs/seco
Energy Systems Laboratory Texas A&M	The "laboratory" in Health & Safety Code § 388.004: publishes the builder self-certification form for unincorporated areas and the IC3 tools.	esl.tamu.edu
TxDOT	District and area offices take Form 1058 driveway applications for access to state-system highways, FM roads included.	txdot.gov

Domains from each agency's own site navigation, read August 2026. This kit prints no phone numbers anywhere — numbers rot; write the one you confirmed in the directory below.

HIGH-VOLUME JURISDICTIONS — OFFICIAL DOMAINS

Offices and official domains (verified August 2026 except as hedged)

Jurisdiction	Office	Domain
Houston	Houston Permitting Center (Houston Public Works) — iPermits/ProjectDox	houstonpermittingcenter.org
San Antonio	Development Services Department — BuildSA portal; forms at docsonline.sanantonio.gov	sa.gov
Fort Worth	Development Services Department — Accela Citizen Access	fortworthtexas.gov
Austin	Development Services Department	austintexas.gov

Offices and official domains (verified August 2026 except as hedged)

Jurisdiction	Office	Domain
Dallas	Development Services / Permitting & Inspections — DallasNow online permitting (launched May 2025)	dallascityhall.com
Montgomery County	Environmental Health / Permitting — septic and development permits; no residential building permit (the county's own FAQ says so)	mctx.org
Comal County	County Engineer's Office — OSSF, floodplain, driveway, and 911 address: the county's four standard permits, one office	comalcounty.gov
Hays County	Development Services — all development plus OSSF in unincorporated areas, via MyGovernmentOnline	hayscountytexas.gov
El Paso County	Public Works — the verified worked example of a Subchapter F residential inspection program (since January 1, 2013)	epcounty.com
Parker County	Domain only — septic/floodplain/development offices exist but were not individually verified; confirm the issuing office	parkercountytexas.com
Hood County	Domain only — same hedge as Parker: confirm the issuing office	co.hood.tx.us

SEARCH PATTERNS FOR EVERYONE ELSE**Finding the right office for your parcel**

Office	How to find it
City permit office	Search "[<i>your city</i>] TX residential building permit" and land only on the .gov / official domain. Ask which portal they use and register before you file.
OSSF authorized agent	TCEQ's authorized-agent lookup map (tceq.texas.gov, OSSF program pages) tells you whether your county, another local government, or TCEQ itself permits your septic system.
County floodplain administrator	Search "[<i>your county</i>] TX floodplain administrator" — often inside the county engineer's or development services office. Every NFIP county has one.
Groundwater conservation district	Most of Texas is districted. Use the district maps published by TCEQ and the Texas Water Development Board, then call the district BEFORE drilling — even an exempt domestic well commonly needs district registration and spacing clearance.
TxDOT district / area office	txdot.gov → Districts; the local area office takes the Form 1058 driveway application for state-system roads.

Finding the right office for your parcel

Office	How to find it
Electric utility, new-construction desk	Whoever serves the lot — co-op or IOU — ask for the new-construction / builder services desk and their meter-loop inspection requirements before you wire (see TX.3).

YOUR DIRECTORY — FILL THIS IN BEFORE YOU NEED IT

Confirm each entry by phone rather than copying it from a search result, and write the date you confirmed it. Note the name of the person you spoke to — in a county office, having a name is worth more than having a number.

CITY PERMITS / PLANNING — Track A permits; or the ETJ answer in writing

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

COUNTY DEVELOPMENT / ENGINEER — floodplain, driveway/culvert, development permits, Subchapter F question

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

OSSF AUTHORIZED AGENT — septic permit and inspections

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

GROUNDWATER DISTRICT — well registration/permit and spacing — before drilling

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

TxDOT AREA OFFICE — Form 1058 driveway permit, if on a state road

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

TDI WINDSTORM / ENGINEER — coastal only — WPI-1 and phase inspections

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

ELECTRIC UTILITY — temporary power; meter-loop release requirements

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

PRIVATE CODE-CERTIFIED INSPECTOR — your Track B quality gate and energy-code route

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

Sources (verified August 2026): ETJ release — Loc. Gov't Code §§ 42.101, 42.102, 42.105(d). Agency and jurisdiction domains — each organization's own site, as tabled above; Parker and Hood County rows are domain-only and hedged. Statutes at statutes.capitol.texas.gov.